

Patriotism can take many forms. For some, it is expressed through military service, political engagement, or civic leadership. For others, it is reflected in quiet but powerful acts of service within their own communities. Patriotism can mean giving time and energy to strengthen the place one calls home, because a country is only as strong as the communities that make it up. One of the most meaningful ways I have been able to show support for America is through volunteering at a local public library, where I learned that patriotism begins with service, empathy, and helping others grow.

The library has been at the heart of our town for more than a century, providing not just books but also knowledge, support, and connection for generations. From its humble beginnings in a small home to its current role as a hub for technology, education, and community resilience, even during challenges such as natural disasters and the Covid-19 pandemic, the library has embodied the American ideals of opportunity and service. By volunteering there, I became part of this legacy of strengthening the community, and in doing so, I realized that my actions, however small, could reflect the patriotism of giving back.

Through this volunteer work, I served as a tech assistant, helping senior citizens navigate the confusing but necessary world of technology. Many came in frustrated and discouraged, but together we found solutions whether it was setting up an email account, figuring out how to operate a smartphone, or learning to use online resources. These moments reminded me that patriotism is not always loud or dramatic; sometimes it is simply ensuring that every generation can fully participate in the society that we have today. In a democracy that thrives on equal access, digital literacy is a modern day necessity, and I was proud to help bridge that gap.

I also had the privilege of teaching introductory coding classes to middle school students at the library. Sharing a passion for technology with the younger generation was deeply rewarding, especially when I saw their excitement as they understood new concepts. In those classrooms, I was reminded that education represents one of America's greatest promises: that knowledge is open to all and that anyone, regardless of age or background, can learn and dream. By teaching, I was investing in the future leaders, innovators, and citizens of this country. Helping these students grow felt like a small but meaningful way to strengthen America's future.

Volunteering was not always easy. Speaking in front of groups and working with strangers pushed me out of my comfort zone. At times, I felt uncertain and hesitant. But through these challenges, I gained confidence in myself and realized that patriotism also means growing into the kind of citizen who can step up, speak out, and contribute when needed. Supporting a community requires courage, and that courage, I firmly believe, is one of the truest forms of patriotism.

To me, patriotism is not just about waving a flag or singing the national anthem. It is about fully embracing the values that make America strong: service, community, equality, and opportunity. By volunteering at a local library, I was able to embody those values in small but meaningful ways. Whether it was helping a senior citizen feel less overwhelmed by technology

or inspiring a middle schooler to pursue coding, I was not just supporting a town. I was supporting the nation. When we build stronger communities, we build a stronger America as a whole.

Ultimately, my time volunteering taught me that patriotism is about responsibility and action. It is about using one's skills, time, and voice to make a difference where they are. For me, that difference began in the heart of a community, and it is there that I learned one of the greatest lessons of all, to paraphrase the words of former president Theodore Roosevelt: "Patriotism means service to the nation; and only those who render such service are fit to enjoy the privilege of citizenship."